

Pages Router — the `pages/` top-level folder

Live demo: `/` and `/api/hello` — run this app separately. **Code:** `examples/pages-router/pages/`

What it is

Before the App Router (`app/`), Next.js routed via the `pages/` directory. It's still supported and listed as a top-level folder in the docs. This tiny app exists to show what `pages/` looks like, for contrast.

How `pages/` routing works

File	URL
<code>pages/index.tsx</code>	<code>/</code>
<code>pages/about.tsx</code>	<code>/about</code>
<code>pages/blog/[slug].tsx</code>	<code>/blog/:slug</code>
<code>pages/api/hello.ts</code>	<code>/api/hello</code> (API)

The **default export** of a file is the page. There are no `layout` / `loading` / `error` special files; shared UI uses a custom `pages/_app.tsx`, and the document shell uses `pages/_document.tsx`.

App Router vs Pages Router (interview-ready)

Topic	Pages Router (<code>pages/</code>)	App Router (<code>app/</code>)
Routing unit	a file's default export	a <code>page.tsx</code> in a folder
Components	Client by default	Server Components by default
Layouts	manual (<code>_app</code> , per-page)	built-in nested <code>layout.tsx</code>
Data fetching	<code>getServerSideProps</code> / <code>getStaticProps</code> / <code>getStaticPaths</code>	<code>async / await</code> in Server Components; <code>generateStaticParams</code>
API	<code>pages/api/*</code> default handler (<code>req,res</code>)	<code>route.ts</code> with <code>GET</code> / <code>POST</code> exports
Loading/Error UI	manual	<code>loading.tsx</code> / <code>error.tsx</code>
Streaming/Suspense	limited	first-class

Can they coexist?

Yes — `app/` and `pages/` can live in the same project during migration, but a given URL must be owned by only one of them. New apps should use `app/`.

Interview Q&A

- Q: What's the difference between `pages/` and `app/` ?** `pages/` is the older file-as-route system (client components by default, `getServerSideProps`); `app/` is the modern router with Server Components, nested layouts, and special files (`layout` , `loading` , `error` , `route`).
- Q: Where do API routes go in each?** Pages Router: `pages/api/*.ts` (default handler). App Router: `route.ts` with

HTTP-method exports.